

CEREAL

ALONG WITH A COMPLETE BREAKFAST, PROVIDES ESSENTIAL VITAMINS, MINERALS AND SHORT STORIES!

IRRELEVANCY

Sunrise. Sunset. Three days holed up in a hotel room in some city; I'm not even sure of its name. It's irrelevant, really.

Irrelevance has been the focus of my most recent depression.

Time is irrelevant. Love is irrelevant. Reality and all the lies that come with it are irrelevant. Life is just one big exercise in irrelevancy.

Day in. Day out.

The same routine. Staring at a blank TV screen and smoking cigarettes. Not eating. Drinking water from the faucet.

But maybe today I'll go outside. Maybe today I'll go outside and remind myself there is a world behind those green and white curtains, a world with people and life.

A world that has never accepted me as a human being or a writer. A world I never have and never will belong in. A world filled with irrelevancy.

No, I don't think I will go outside today. Instead I deal myself another hand of solitaire and wait for something to happen.

Just like everyone else.



BY LUC
THIERS

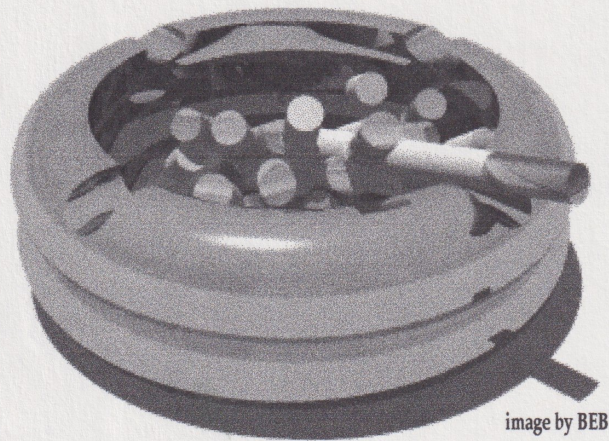


image by BEB

The Ex Communication

Took the time to look up an ex. The phone number was comically easy to locate...

"Bringg Bringg, Bringg Bringg, Bringg Bringg, Bringg Br... Hello?"

"Uh, hi. Is April there?"

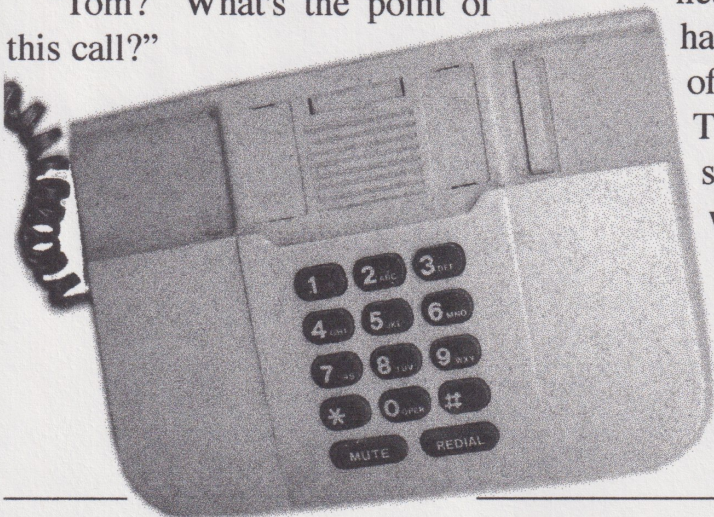
"Speaking," she commented with the shy strut of a cheetah in heat.

"Yeah, hey! This is Tom Benjamin... Remember me?"

"Yeah, in fact I do. Weren't...."

I finished her sentence: "...we completely devoted to each other before you left me for Ralph Timmins 'cause you found his neurotic habit of eating paste strangely erotic? Yes, we were. And now I'm a better person despite you and the times we shared."

"Tom? What's the point of this call?"



by **Garrett
Kramer**

"Well, you were a good person to me, and despite the past, I think we could make it work."

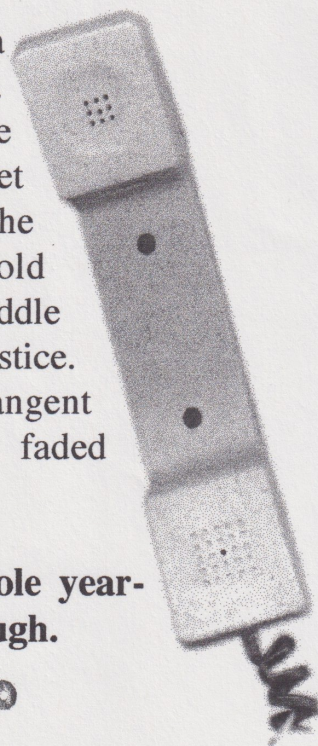
There was a silence as long as twelve bar mitzvahs.

"Tom, we were in second grade."

Click.

The noise struck a chord with me. Struck a chord the same way hippie street performers strike the hearts of 16-year-old halter-tops in the middle of the Summer Solstice. This thought tangent sparked, but then faded when I realized...

...I had a whole year-book to go through.



Panic & Revulsion in WASHINGTON D.C.

Part VII - Washintussin DM: Obey Your Thirst.

Almost everything in this entire series is true. As the story progresses, I will let you, the reader, in on the things that didn't actually happen. Previous chapters are available on the Cereal Website at <http://www.hellskitchen.org/cereal>

Monday 6/29/98:

It was well past dawn when I woke up, at the rest area off of I95, the one near Scaggsville, in the car behind the wheel, feeling raw and used, wearing nothing except the seat belt. The sun had turned the dark car with dark interior into an oven. Beads of perspiration were covering my body, which already had six layers of dried sweat, and at least one of them wasn't mine. It was much sweeter.

Where were my clothes? Where, for that matter, was Jason? Had Valerie kept him behind for some nefarious reason?

I made a self assessment: Hung over? Not really. Feeling strange. Like I. Not Myself. Almost like I. Not quite. World's different. I don't remember the sky being blue. Not that particular blue.

Shadows of memories of the night before: Paralyzation. Sensuous movement. A surprise. Door splinters. Screams. Shrilling screams. Loud deep screams. Gunfire. Gunfire? What happened? Crashing glass? Was

Jason unable to escape? How on earth did I?

Coughing. I certainly remember a lot of coughing. No. I hear it. Where is it coming from? It sounds a little like Jason.

"Help! Cough cough. Help! Cough cough." Then there was a loud thumping noise coming from behind me.

I popped the trunk and quickly put on some clothes from my knapsack that laid in the back seat. When I got the rear of the car I saw Jason's limp and naked torso hanging halfway out and near death. After a cool, brisk dawn, the heat had built up throughout the morning to unbearable levels. Jason was looking and sounding very ill. He had been roasted *au jois*.

I asked, "Do you remember...?"

"Nothing," he weakly interrupted, punctuating his condition with a long series of coughing fits. I opened his backpack and took out some clothes.

"I'll go get some wet paper towels and a map of DC. I think the visitor center is open by now. Are you okay enough to get dressed? The con-

Written by
**BRIAN
BARRETT**

I'M NOT GOING TO
SURVIVE, I SAID
HALF WEEPING AND
FELL TO MY
KNEES, LEANING
BACK, WAITING FOR
THE BUZZARDS TO
START CIRCLING.

ference starts in five and a half hours," I was still half asleep and didn't believe myself when I hoarsely said the words: "We should get there early to check out the convention."

We arrived in downtown Washington D.C. at 9:15 am and without serious incident. I parked as near to the location as I could according to the star on the map that I had printed off the Internet -- about a mile. Fortunately, last night, in an unusual moment of foresight, Jason had put most of our cash in the glove box.

He counted out fifty dollars to carry with him while I grabbed the box of the five hundred back issues of Hell's Kitchen, and we started the trek: through a park, past the Botanical Gardens, across the grounds of the Capital building, through another park, around a reflecting pool, through another park, up a block, make a left, up another block, turn around, two blocks, another park, another reflecting pool, or the same one, who knows, another park, a big fountain, up a block, take a right, ask for directions: "Two more blocks."

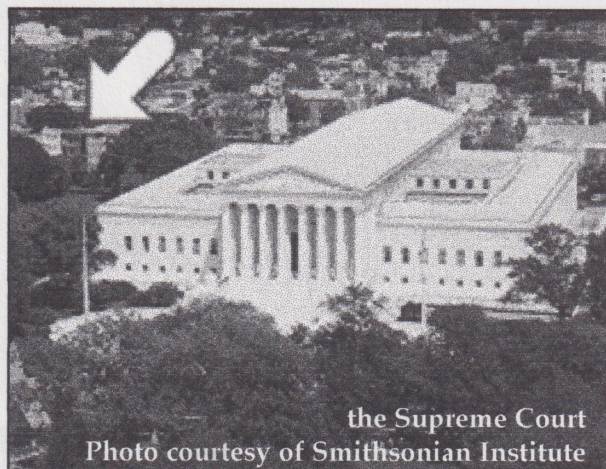
Being dressed in a black sports jacket under the bright unforgiving sun, carrying a large cardboard box full of papers across the heart of the nation with a similarly dressed companion who is coughing continuously and limping horribly is an interesting mixture of different thoughts and sensations. I don't know why. It just is.

"Slow down! (Cough! Cough!) My (Cough! Cough!) toe! (Cough!)"

I had forgotten about that. Before we left he was looking for me to promise that there wouldn't be too much walking, on account of a third

and second degree burn he had on his big toe. Up until now, there was very little walking at all. Luckily, I didn't promise him anything. I did slow down a little, though. I'm not completely without compassion.

I had accidentally left the printout of the informational E-mail at home, but was able to remember that the convention was at the Stuart Mott House, 122 Maryland Ave, NE, across the street from the Supreme Court building. This, as it turned out, was not entirely correct recall. The information also stated that Counterpoise and the Independent



the Supreme Court

Photo courtesy of Smithsonian Institute

Press Association would be in booth number two-thousand and one-hundred sixty-something. 122 Maryland Ave, NE, across from the Supreme Court building, is a modest townhouse, and half of it is the National Headquarters of the ACLU.

"Ahem! Cough! This doesn't look right. Cough!"

"Let's check it out anyways. Maybe they know where the convention is."

Inside was like walking into heaven after crawling through hell. The central air conditioner was almost too refreshing too quickly, and I was afraid we were going to get the temperature equivalent of the bends.

The receptionist didn't know about any convention or conference or banquet. But it was the Stewart Mott House, and I remembered that's where at least some of those events were being held. I asked directions for the nearest convention center and a place to keep Jason, the box of issues and my jacket while I go back and get the car. Where did I park? Jason had a hard time remembering, too, and the receptionist wasn't any help, either. Screw it. I left the box and jacket there and took Jason out for a walk. The convention center was probably just as close as the car.

It was a little past eleven now. Under the suggestion of the receptionist we stopped at the

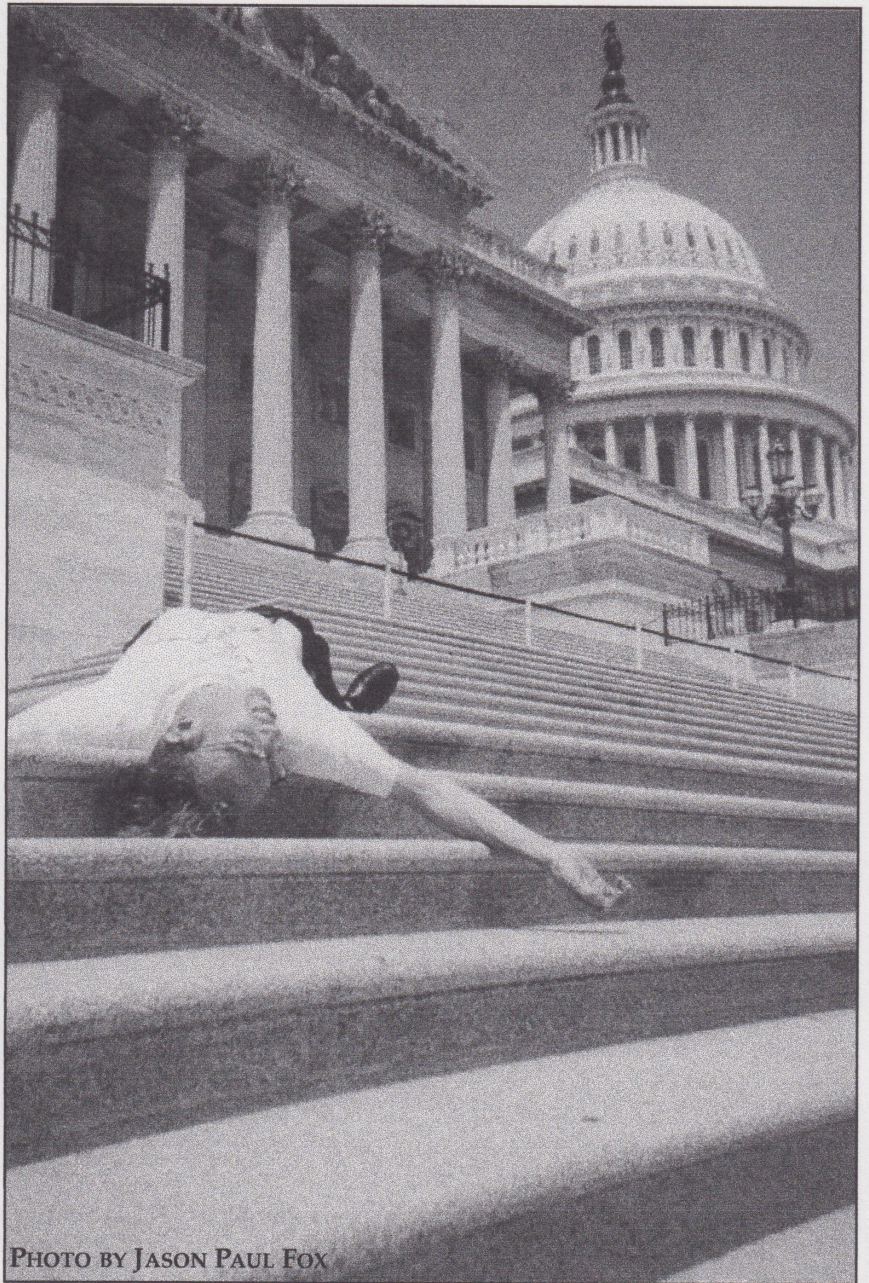


PHOTO BY JASON PAUL FOX

Supreme Court building commissary for some brunch. It brought back memories. I haven't been through a metal detector to get to a cafeteria since highschool.

The prices were outrageous. The salad bar was billed ala-cart. "Ten cents per crouton?" I protested to the business suited, gray haired man

behind me in line, "You call that justice?"

He replied "Don't tell anyone, but this whole place is a sham."

After eating my \$3.50 dry hamburger with ten cents worth of lettuce and a twenty-five cent slice of tomato on a fifteen cent dry bun washed down with a two dollar twelve-ounce soda, I waited for Jason to stop poking at his adventurous four dollar bowl of New England clam chowder. He had to eat most of it twice, because he kept on coughing up little bits.

Leaving the Supreme Court we knew what it felt like to be reamed by the Judicial system.

We walked a couple of blocks and came across a CVS. Jason needed to go in and get some cough syrup, and I needed some iced tea. We were dehydrated in the 102 degree blue sky weather. Within a block, I drank all of tea, which went straight through my pores and soaked my shirt, and Jason drank all of his Robotussin. After another two long, slow blocks, I was still thirsty, and Jason was still coughing. Then we found another drug store.

I was busy asking for an update on our directions from a meter maid while Jason went into the store to update our supplies. When he came out, he was carrying a bag containing six 8 ounce bottles of cough syrup.

"Where's my tea?"

"I didn't (cough!) know you needed (cough!) any!"

"I'll get it. Give me a couple bucks."

"I spent it all (cough cough) on the Tussin."

"All of it?"

"I got," He put his hand in his pocket and pulled out a dime, nickel, and two pennies.

"I'm not going to survive," I said half weeping and fell to my knees, leaning back, waiting for the buzzards to start circling.

"Sorry, (cough, cough)" To his credit, his apology was sincere. He looked like he was about to cry. "I'm just (cough) a little out of it. (cough, cough)"

"Now what?"

He opened up a bottle and handed it to me. We started walking, and we started drinking.

The first four ounces were the worst. The second four ounces were horrible. I didn't like the next four ounces at all. After the second bottle, my opinion of the taste stayed the same, but my opinion of Washington D.C. was getting rosier.

We rounded a corner and found ourselves on the Mall. A vast open area of brown thirsty grass reflecting heat in illusionary mirage. Nomadic tourists, all younger or far older than us, armed with cameras, trudged across the bordered desert in search of the tourist trappings of a nation and gave us no attention as we crept along the flat landscape. No one must know our terrible secret. No one.



TO BE CONTINUED IN NEXT CEREAL:

*Panic & Revulsion in
WASHINGTON D.C.*

-Part VIII-

BAKIN' SCARE OF DIZZ'NESS

Now in breathing color! [HTTP://www.hellskitchen.org/cereal](http://www.hellskitchen.org/cereal)

Cereal Magazine

Words Escape Me

Because I'm from Mars.”
“No, really, why won't you go out with me?” he stepped in double time to keep up with her ever increasing pace. “You're not still mad about that thing I did with those napkins last week, are you?”

“It was yesterday, Doug, yesterday,” and she fought with her legs to try to re-double the speed of her step.

“Yeah, whatever. Right. So, but, you're not mad about that. I mean, you can't be.”

“Sweetheart, don't under-estimate me,” then she re-evaluated what she had said, “No, I'm not angry about that.” She was walking so quickly that her own train of thought had a hard time keeping up.

“So what is it? You trying to play some a that hard ta get bitch-ass bullshit? I'm not down with that shit. You don't have to play that with me. I like ya' just the way ya're.”

“Don't you have a class to go to?” she held her head down in avoidance, watching her sneakers disappear and reappear beneath her like the pounding turbines of heavy machinery in Industrial Revolution documentaries. “Na, I got lunch now.”

Why do have to talk like you're uneducated white-trash and not the son of a Sunday school teacher and division

director at Xerox? She thought.

“Come on babe, I know what you need.”

This blatant sexual reference broke the dam.

“You just don't freaking get it. you stupid SOB!”

“I'm not just any SOB I'm your SOB”

She desperately tried to ward him off as they walked together down into the realm that divides the consciousness from time.

“I hate you,” she snarled, like his ignorance had given her rabies.

“Awe. Come on baby, ya know ya don't hate me. Ya know this is the stuff yer dreams is made of. So when ya wanna do it, really?” He faltered for a moment to attempt to lift and rest three extra inches of pant circumference upon his non-existent hips.

by
Marisa
Brandt

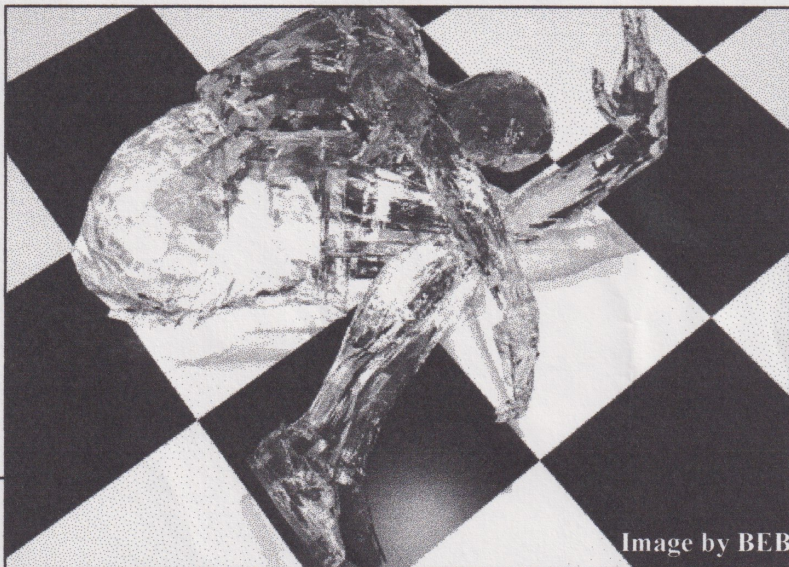


Image by BEB

She stopped, inertia almost making her kiss the linoleum, and turned her head, shoulders, bins, feet to face him, "I have dreams," she couldn't help but shine a smile at the thought "Yes, Doug, I have great many, actually. And while a few might seem petty to some, I can assure you that none are quite so pathetic as wanting any such troll as yourself as my willing companion."

He looked at her flabbergasted and dumfounded from under the brim of his cap.

"Awe," He fastened his palms to her shoulders, "You just tense. I know what you need." This is the point where she began to scream. It started as a tremor, a pus-y yellow vibration at the points where his vessel touched hers and climbed the Richter scale as it neared her core until she let forth such an anguished vein of pain as only a mother knows, because it is the

sound that she fears most. She screamed until her eyes began to cry tears of blood. She screamed until her muscles were so taut as they almost ripped from their very places of anchorage on her bones. She screamed until she could not hear him. She screamed until she could not remember him. She screamed until there was no palpable world. She screamed until her thoughts were thin black liquid poured from an empty flask. And then, she stopped.

She huddled herself into a fetal ball, pulling in her appendages for all the protection her own matter could provide for itself. She sobbed and cried and rocked and cooed to herself, preparing for perception to return. He watched down at her, eyebrows pushed together in concern.

"Geez, why dint'ja just tell me ya weren't int'rested?" and he walked away.



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